

Find out why
your business
can't afford to
take **twitter**
as just another
passing fad to take
cyberspace
by storm

twitter

for your Business

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The Twitter phenomenon

Twitter.com is a free social networking service that began operations in 2006. The service allows users to post short (140 character) updates. The service is like a short message service over the web, which allows users to keep friends and family in the loop. Once you sign up, you get a customisable page. You can post to this page from your mobile phone, the internet, or any one of the myriad tools available for the purpose. You can "follow" other people who use twitter, and have their posts show up on your page too, which is called a "stream". Twitter encourages you to post *What are you doing now?*, which gives an element of immediate, and real-time updates about people. Twitter can be seen as a social networking site at heart, but its users have transcended the roots of the service. It is the most used social networking site for business purposes, far ahead of the closest competitors, Facebook and Myspace. Twitter has gained an

identity for itself, and can be compared on many counts, to the phenomenon of blogging.

The first blogs brought with them a whole bunch of blogging related lingo and terms. The same is true for Twitter. A Twitter post is called a *tweet*, Twitter users are *tweeple*, and the sum of all tweeple and tweets make up the *tweetosphere*. The blogosphere faced a flurry of harsh criticism,

for being a waste of time, for being blatantly useless, and for being just another tech-age fad. Twitter faces much of the same criticism. There are a whole bunch of dead or orphaned blogs, and the same is already true for Twitter. Respectable people refused to take blogs seriously for the first few years they were around. However, a new class of people, and a strong community emerged from the blogging phenomenon. Those who used the service for its benefits, those who defined the rules, and those who capitalised on the service became the success stories of the blogosphere. The same can be said about Twitter too. Although the service may appear bland, meandering, and foolish in the eyes of many, rest assured that there will be those that will use it for their benefit. Twitter, like blogger, is a new space, and a new medium. Many businesses are finding it a powerful platform to interact with their customers.

Why your business needs Twitter

The question really is, if you have a business, why do you need to use Twitter? If

you have a business, chances are, that you have customers that are talking about your product, your brand, or your business on Twitter. A search on Twitter of your business should turn up a number of opinions, insights, and issues that your customers have with your business. We headed out to <http://search.twitter.com/> and searched for this magazine. We came across reports of

when our forums were down, of what kind of content we carry in our magazine, and how users could not use certain kinds of content on our DVD. All of this was legitimate and valuable feedback. Twitter lets you know in real-time, what people are talking about your business. Follow those who talk about your business, or your costumers, and you get to gauge the mood of your audience, what is occupying them, and what they need.

Next, you can look at what people are talking about your competition. Check out their faults, their weaknesses, and what needs they are not fulfilling. Not only do these searches show you what to capitalise on, you get a deeper understanding about your market. Twitter is, at the end of the day a social networking site. People will tweet about the boring things they think no one is interested in. **Twitter.com** considers the cumulative data of all its users as an asset, and any smart business will consider the information with the same value attached to it.

Twitter starts becoming really useful, when a company actively gets into

the tweetosphere instead of passively reading it. Giving something back to the community, entering into the spirit of the endeavour, and participating in the tweetosphere can have a number of benefits for a business, as many CEOs have already found out. Twitter has a sizable number of users to direct traffic to the company's web site. Twitter gives the company a face and a personality, making the company itself a tangible entity that customers can interact with. This brings the customers and the business closer together, and both stand to benefit.

If you are unsure of which direction to take your business in, or how your customers will react to a certain approach, Twitter is a great place to get that feedback. Twitter can be used to seed thoughts and ideas, generate buzz about events, and stay tuned to the pulse of your market, or your audience.

If this impressive list does not convince you to get your business on Twitter, perhaps this will – chances are, that your competition is thinking of, or is already active, on Twitter.

Setting up a Twitter account

To set up a twitter page for your business, all you have to do is sign up for a handle at www.twitter.com. A handle is akin to a username, but can be used in a variety of ways. You can be followed by tweeple, or customers can choose to get updates from your business on their mobile phones. If it is a small company, the name of the company will do fine as the handle. Alternatively, if you want to keep it more personal, you can choose to use your own name as the handle, but still use the account as a proxy Twitter account for the company. If it is a large company, it is customary in the tweetosphere to use the first-name-at-company format – adityaatdigit, for example. A number of employees dealing